Some thought he would commit suicide. When it was time to leave, Honecker went up to the second floor to fix all his belongings. The Russian agents wanted to accompany him, arguing that he could take his own life. I told them no. I was convinced that he would not do it, because he was too proud a man and wanted to defend himself.

The sorry saga ended at half-past five in the afternoon, when Holger – holding Honecker's elbow – escorted him from the building. 'When he said goodbye,' Holger remembered, 'he told me: "You always respected my position as former head of state and you respected me as a person. I am deeply grateful to you."'39 (James Holger told the author in 2000, that 'Erich demanded' he be transported to North Korea 'half a dozen times' during this encounter.)

After seven months holed up inside the embassy, the former General Secretary of the Socialist Unity Party of Germany – dressed in a navy-blue suit – emerged with his arm raised in a clenched-fist communist salute. One reporter noted his hair – always so scant and grey – had fallen out. Looking on anxiously, Margot waved goodbye. She would remain in the embassy another day before flying to Chile to join Sonja, ending what she described as months of 'psycho-terror'. That evening, at Vnukovo airport, Erich Honecker was placed on a Soviet Tu-134 civil airliner destined for Berlin. He would never see Russia again.